Countries enjoy a vast array of foreign policy instruments to project power and achieve their objectives. From manipulating trade policies and foreign aid to providing military protection or imposing sanctions, states can leverage both rewards and threats to influence allies and adversaries alike. Great powers often use aid or investments as carrots to secure policy alignment (e.g., aid-for-votes exchanges in the UN General Assembly; Dreher, Sturm, and Vreeland 2015), while simultaneously wielding sticks with which to punish states that stray from their agendas (e.g., through sanctions or tariffs). These tools allow states to assert dominance, build coalitions, and deter opposition.

Like states, IOs deploy a variety of tools to foster cooperation, neutralize opposition, and retain member participation. However, IOs' strategies and capabilities differ markedly from those of states. Unlike nations, IOs cannot mobilize armies or enforce their mandates through territorial control. They operate within narrower issue areas, their funding depends on member contributions, and their authority often lacks enforceability. Threats to IO budgets—such as the Trump administration's efforts to defund key institutions—underscore their vulnerability to external pressures. Indeed, by virtue of their accountability to member-state principals, IOs seemingly possess limited room in which to maneuver.

Yet IOs are not passive bystanders. Far from being mechanical responders, they possess significant agency and deploy it strategically. Scholars have examined many of the individual tactics IOs use to incentivize cooperation, such as adjusting voting rules, modifying conditionalities, or engaging in diplomatic persuasion (Copelovitch 2010; Stone 2011; Carnegie and Clark 2023). However, there is a surprising lack of research on how these tools are combined into cohesive strategies to counter threats, punish hostile members, and nurture long-term cooperation.

IOs face structural and operational constraints that limit their ability to coerce or compel. As supranational entities, they are coalitions of diverse member states, each with their own policy priorities and domestic pressures. Decision making within IOs often requires internal bargaining, making enforcement inconsistent and subject to compromise. Moreover, IOs typically lack direct control over populations or traditional governance organs, further distinguishing their tools from those of states.